Q29: Agent Control and Safety Protocols

Bound authority; validate side effects

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Question

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Is AI controllable, and how do agentic workflows and safety protocols constrain it?

Control is a systems property

- Model + prompts + tools + credentials + workflow + people
- State a bounded control claim, not “the model is safe.”
- Ask: authority, trust boundaries, stop/recovery paths.

Least privilege

- Read vs write; staging vs production
- Scoped, expiring credentials
- High-impact action bound to verified approval

A tool interface is not a trust guarantee.

Prompts are not access control

- Retrieved content can carry indirect prompt injection.
- Treat external text as data, not authority.
- Enforce policy and arguments with deterministic code.

Defense in depth

- Capability/egress limits and sandboxing
- Argument validation and approval binding
- Logging, rate limits, and reversible actions
- Human confirmation for consequential side effects

Evaluate the workflow

- Normal, ambiguous, unauthorized, malformed, injected cases
- Success, false approval/block, intervention, cost, severity
- Preserve held-out tests and environment versions

Human oversight

- Show target, diff, evidence, and consequences.
- Avoid rubber-stamp queues and automation bias.
- Make escalation and stop legitimate outcomes.

Takeaway

Calibrated delegation
Minimize authority, validate side effects, test boundaries, and reserve stronger controls for irreversible or high-impact actions.